

What SSO (Single Sign-On) Is

- SSO allows a user to **sign in once** and then access multiple apps and services **without having to re-enter their password**.
- Managed through identity providers like **Microsoft Entra ID**, which issues and validates the sign-in token.
- Works across Microsoft 365, Azure apps, SaaS apps, and on-premises apps integrated through SSO.

Purpose of SSO

- **Simplify authentication** for users by eliminating repeated sign-ins.
- **Centralize identity management** in one place (Entra ID).
- **Improve security** by reducing password fatigue and encouraging stronger security controls like MFA.
- **Enable seamless productivity** across cloud and on-prem apps.

Security Benefits

- **Reduced password fatigue** → users aren't tempted to reuse simple passwords everywhere.
- **Fewer login prompts** → lowers the risk of phishing.
- **Centralized access control** → admins can block access instantly by disabling the user account.
- **Strong authentication enforcement** → MFA, Conditional Access, and passwordless sign-ins apply consistently across all apps.

Operational Benefits

- **Better user experience** → one login gives access to Teams, Outlook, SharePoint, Line-of-business apps, etc.
- **Fewer helpdesk calls** related to password resets or login troubles.
- **Faster onboarding/offboarding** → access is automatically granted or removed based on Entra ID.
- **Consistent policies** across all connected apps (e.g., session timeouts, device requirements).





Typical SSO Scenario

- User signs into their laptop with their **Entra ID account**.
- They open Outlook → no login prompt.
- They go to SharePoint → no login prompt.
- They launch a third-party app integrated with SSO (Salesforce, ServiceNow, Dropbox) → still no prompt.
- The token issued at sign-in is trusted by all these apps.

How SSO Works at a High Level

- User authenticates once with Entra ID.
- Entra ID issues a **token** that proves the user's identity.
- Apps trust Entra ID → no additional password is required.
- When token expires, Entra can silently reissue a new one without user interaction.

Benefits for IT & Security Teams

- Streamlined access reviews (one identity, many apps).
- Easier compliance & auditing.
- Reduced attack surface from unmanaged identities.
- Consistent enforcement of Conditional Access, device compliance, and MFA.